



MINDFULNESS "WHAT" SKILLS – PARTICIPATE



- **Participating is entering wholly and with awareness into life itself, nonjudgmentally, in the present moment. Participating is the ultimate goal of mindfulness.**

BENEFITS OF PARTICIPATING – WHY DO IT?

- **The experience of FLOW is associated with participating.**
The state of "flow" is considered an optimal experience incompatible with boredom and associated with intense enjoyment and a sense of control.
i.e. Being fully immersed in an activity like skiing, running or painting can give one a sense of maximum well being.
- **Participating is incompatible with Self-Consciousness**
When we "become what we are doing", there is a merging of action and awareness, so that we are no longer aware of ourselves as separate from what we are doing.
- **Participating is incompatible with a Sense of Exclusion**
When we become what we are doing, we are no longer aware of ourselves as separate from what we are doing or from our environment. We lose awareness of the separation of ourselves and everything else. We forget ourselves and forget to be aware of ourselves as inside or outside.
- **In Participating, Effort seems Effortless**
In a state of flow, there is an effortlessness of action. We are absorbed entirely in what we are doing and what is happening. We are aware of a sense of movement, speed and ease. Life and what we are doing become like a dance. Even great effort seems effortless.
- **In Participating, we are present to our lives and the lives of loved ones**
When we become what we are doing, we do not miss out on our own lives. We also do not miss out on being part of the lives of others. Compassion and love, towards others, and ourselves requires our presence.
- **Participating is an important characteristic of Skillful Behaviour**
To be experts at any task, we must practice and overlearn that task. Expertise in any activity requires mindful awareness of the task without the distractions of thinking about ourselves, others or even that task itself. A person who thinks about running while running loses the race. In great acting, the actor becomes the role. A great dancer becomes the dance.

PARTICIPATING – WHAT TO DO?



- Enter into present experiences. Immerse yourself in the present.
- Throw yourself completely into activities
- Don't separate yourself from ongoing events and interactions. Engage completely; immerse yourself in the moment; become involved; join with; opt in.
- Become one with what you are doing
- Let go of self-consciousness by acting opposite to it. (opposite action) Abandon yourself to the moment. Concentrate in the moment such that you and what you are doing become "merged" as if there is only now, and only what you are doing.
- Act intuitively from Wise Mind, doing just what is needed in each situation.
- Go with the flow; respond with spontaneity.

i.e. Observing and Describing are like "STOP, LOOK and LISTEN". Participating is like walking across the street.

"If it is raining, just play in the puddles like a kid would; enjoy the rain."

CHOOSING WHEN TO OBSERVE, WHEN TO DESCRIBE and WHEN TO PARTICPATE

- **Observe and Describe when something is difficult.**

Step back from participating in an activity when you are making errors or don't know how to do something. When you are participating you are very aware but you are not actively focusing your attention on yourself and analyzing the details of what you are doing. At times you must step back, slow down, and pay attention to what you are doing. In particular, when you notice there is a problem in your life, you need to step back and actively observe and describe both the problem situation and your response to it. You can then figure out what's wrong, learn the skills need to solve the problem, and return to participating.

We step back from participating to understand and improve things.

i.e. If you are a driver – when you switch cars to one with a different way of driving, or if you go to the UK and have to drive on the left side of the road; you suddenly need to stop, observe and describe.

i.e. You can only play the piano really well when you participate in the act of piano playing – that is, if you play fully. But if you've learned an incorrect technique, you may want to learn the correct version. To do so, you have to step back and observe and describe what you are doing wrong, then practice the correct way over and over until you are skilled. You can then stop observing and participate again.

- **Do the Most Practice of the Most Difficult Skill**

Devote most practice to the mindfulness skill you find most difficult. Different people have trouble with different skills.

i.e. Some people participate all the time and that is their problem. They don't notice that they are participating in a way that is driving others crazy. Other people have a lot of trouble with participating, especially those who are shy, socially anxious, or afraid of failing. All they do is stay on the sidelines and observe. Still others have busy analytical minds. They also stay back from living fully in the moment, but instead of just observing they are analyzing, thinking and ruminating about each event as it occurs. Life is like a running commentary on the universe. Describing is in overdrive.

Which "WHAT" skill is your strength? Which is your weakness?

- **Remember to use one WHAT skill at a time – when observing, observe; when describing, describe; when you are participating, fully participate.**



THE STATE OF "FLOW"

"The best moments in our lives are not the passive, receptive, relaxing times... The best moments usually occur if a person's body or mind is stretched to its limits in a voluntary effort to accomplish something difficult and worthwhile." ~ Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi (1990, p. 3)

Psychologist Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi discovered that people find genuine satisfaction during a state of consciousness called "FLOW". In this state, people are completely absorbed in an activity, especially an activity which involves their creative abilities. During this "optimal experience" they feel "strong, alert, in effortless control, unselfconscious, and at the peak of their abilities."

People experience FLOW when:

1. They have clear, articulated goals
2. They get immediate feedback
3. They take on an achievable but challenging task
4. They merge their awareness and their actions
5. They become immersed and undistracted
6. They have high levels of control and don't worry about failure
7. They step outside their own sense of self
8. They encounter a feeling of timelessness
9. The activity becomes an end unto itself

Five ways that we can increase the chances of experiencing FLOW:

1. Set goals that have clear and immediate feedback
2. Become immersed and focused on a particular activity
3. Pay attention to what is happening in the moment
4. Learn to enjoy immediate experience
5. Proportion your skills to the challenge at hand

